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Topic 1: Navigating the Leadership Transition

From Individual Contributor to First-Line Manager

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Session flow

Here's How We'll Spend the Next Three Hours

9:00 – 9:10	Welcome & Frame	Kick-off
9:10 – 9:35	The Mindset Shift	LO1
9:35 – 10:10	Group Activity 1: Spot the Trap	LO1 applied
10:10 – 10:30	Debrief & Bridge	LO1 → LO2
10:30 – 10:45	Break	
10:45 – 11:15	Assessing Team Readiness	LO2
11:15 – 11:45	Group Activity 2: Match the Delegation	LO3
11:45 – 12:00	Build Your Transition Plan	LO4

By the end of today

You Will Be Able To...

1. Explain the shift from individual contributor to manager.
2. Identify team members' strengths and development needs.
3. Adapt guidance and task allocation to individual capability.
4. Create a practical leadership transition plan.

The mindset shift

Your Job Has Changed – Now You Have to Change With It.

IC **Individual Contributor**



- Success = personal output
- Win by doing the work yourself
- Focus: your own tasks and craft

M **First-Line Manager**



- Success = team output
- Win by building capability in others
- Focus: growth, accountability, culture

Source: Hill, L. A. (2007). Becoming the boss. Harvard Business Review, 85(1), 48–56.

Four stages of contribution, and where you sit today

A Career Is a Journey, Not a Job

	Stage 1: Contributing Dependently	Stage 2: Contributing Independently	Stage 3: Contributing Through Others	Stage 4: Contributing Strategically
Performance Expectation	Build credibility, learn	Establish and apply expertise	Guide, coordinate, develop others	Shape organizational direction
Primary Role	Helper, learner	Individual contributor, specialist	Coach, mentor, idea leader, internal consultant, project leader	Sponsor, innovator, business leader
Major Stage Transition Issue	Recognize need for dependence	Accept independence	Accept responsibility (formal or informal) for others' efforts	Holistic view of business, making tough choices
Performance	Support others, build credibility	Individual capability, subject matter expertise	Relationships, networks, and technical breadth	Establish organizational priorities, broad impact and influence

Source: Dalton, G. W., Thompson, P. H., & Price, R. L. (1977). The four stages of professional careers: A new look at performance by professionals. Organizational Dynamics, 6(1), 19–42.

Reference framework · Hill (2007)

Five Common Myths Explain Why New Managers Don't Get It.

Beginning managers often fail, at least initially, because they carry misconceptions about what it means to be a boss. Because these myths are simplistic and incomplete, they lead new managers to neglect key leadership responsibilities.

	Myth	Reality
Defining characteristic of the new role	**Authority** *"Now I will have the freedom to implement my ideas."*	
Source of power	**Formal authority** *"I will finally be on top of the ladder."*	
Desired outcome	**Control** *"I must get compliance from my subordinates."*	
Managerial focus	**Managing one-on-one** *"My role is to build relationships with individual subordinates."*	
Key challenge	**Keeping the operation in working order** *"My job is to make sure the operation runs smoothly."*	

Source: Hill, L. A. (2007). Becoming the boss. Harvard Business Review, 85(1), 48–56.

Reference framework · Hill (2007)

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	Myth	Reality
Defining characteristic of the new role	**Authority** *"Now I will have the freedom to implement my ideas."*	**Interdependency** *"It's humbling that someone who works for me could get me fired."*
Source of power	**Formal authority** *"I will finally be on top of the ladder."*	**"Everything but"** *"Folks were wary, and you really had to earn it."*
Desired outcome	**Control** *"I must get compliance from my subordinates."*	**Commitment** *"Compliance does not equal commitment."*
Managerial focus	**Managing one-on-one** *"My role is to build relationships with individual subordinates."*	**Leading the team** *"I need to create a culture that will allow the group to fulfill its potential."*
Key challenge	**Keeping the operation in working order** *"My job is to make sure the operation runs smoothly."*	**Making changes that improve team performance** *"I am responsible for initiating changes to enhance the group's performance."*

Source: Hill, L. A. (2007). Becoming the boss. Harvard Business Review, 85(1), 48–56.

Setting up the problem

You're Not Alone – Nearly Half of New Managers Underperform.

~50%

of newly promoted managers
underperform within their first 18 months

Not from lack of talent.

From carrying individual-contributor habits into a job that no longer rewards them. Research on first-time managers keeps surfacing the same three failure points – the traps on the next slides.

Source: Smith, D. D. (2023, May 17). 5 mistakes new managers make. Harvard Business Review.

Trap 1 of 3

If You Keep Doing the Work Yourself, Your Team Never Learns To.

1

Doing the work instead of building the capability to do it without you.

The instinct is understandable – you were promoted because you were excellent at the work. But every time you jump in because you're faster, your team learns nothing. Watkins (2013) frames this as failing to make the mental shift from "doer" to "leader"; Hill (2007) documents it as the single hardest transition new managers report.



Source: Hill, L. A. (2007). Becoming the boss. Harvard Business Review, 85(1), 48–56; Watkins, M. D. (2013). The first 90 days. Harvard Business Review Press.

Trap 2 of 3

You Avoid Delegating Because It Feels Like Losing Control.

2

“It’s faster if I just do it” – usually without a real readiness check behind it.

First-time managers consistently rank “adjusting to people management and displaying authority” among their top challenges – many avoid delegating not because their team can’t handle the work, but because handing it over feels like losing control. Left unaddressed, this caps how much the team can actually deliver.



Source: Gentry, W. A., Logan, P., & Tonidandel, S. (2014). Understanding the leadership challenges of first-time managers. Center for Creative Leadership; Smith, D. D. (2023). 5 mistakes new managers make. Harvard Business Review.

Trap 3 of 3

Your Accountability Problems Start With Expectations You Never Made Explicit.

3

Assuming people know what's expected instead of saying it out loud and confirming it landed.

Most "accountability" failures trace back to something that was never actually made explicit – what "done" looks like, how often to check in, what to escalate versus decide. Hill (2007) found this ambiguity was often invisible to the new manager, who assumed clarity existed where it didn't.



Source: Hill, L. A. (2007). Becoming the boss. Harvard Business Review, 85(1), 48–56; Gentry, Logan, & Tonidandel (2014). Center for Creative Leadership.

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Group activity 1

Now, Spot the Trap in Your Own Team.

How it works

1. Form groups of 8 members
2. Each person shares one real moment – from your own experience – where a trap showed up
3. As a group, name which trap(s) were at play
4. Discuss what a different response could have looked like
5. Pick one story and prepare a one-line lesson for debrief

Debrief question

Which trap shows up most in your own team right now?



Take a 15-Minute Break – You've Earned It.

Back at 10:45 – next up: where "direct, coach, motivate, delegate" comes from, then matching delegation to capability.

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Readiness-based delegation

You Can't Use One Style on Everyone – Adapt to Their Readiness.

These four styles aren't arbitrary. They come from Hersey and Blanchard's life cycle theory of leadership (1969) – one of the most widely used people-management models. The core idea: effective leaders don't have one fixed style, they adapt based on how ready a person is for a given task.

1

Telling

Direct

Low readiness

Give clear instructions and supervise closely.

2

Selling

Coach

Some readiness

Explain your reasoning; stay involved, invite questions.

3

Participating

Motivate

Growing readiness

Share the decision; support their confidence.

4

Delegating

Delegate

High readiness

Hand over responsibility and authority.

Landsberg (1996) later repackaged this as the practical "skill/will matrix" used in coaching – the version you'll use on the next two slides.

Source: Hersey, P., & Blanchard, K. H. (1969). Life cycle theory of leadership. Training and Development Journal, 23, 26–35; Landsberg, M. (1996). The Tao of coaching. HarperCollins Business.

Readiness-based delegation

Let Skill and Will, Not Seniority, Decide How Much You Delegate.

Skill

Can they actually do this task – do they have the technical ability and experience?

Will

Are they motivated and confident enough to take it on right now?

Cross the two and you get the same four styles from the last slide, mapped onto a working tool: direct, coach, motivate, delegate.

Source: Adapted from Hersey, P., & Blanchard, K. H. (1969). Life cycle theory of leadership. Training and Development Journal, 23, 26–35; and Landsberg, M. (1996). The Tao of Coaching. HarperCollins Business.

Readiness-based delegation

You Can't Guess Skill and Will – You Have to Go Find Out.

Skill

Their track record on similar work – not tenure or job title.

The quality of a small, real test assignment.

How they explain their approach when you ask "how would you tackle this?"

Will

Whether they volunteer, or need asking twice.

Follow-through over time – not just one instance.

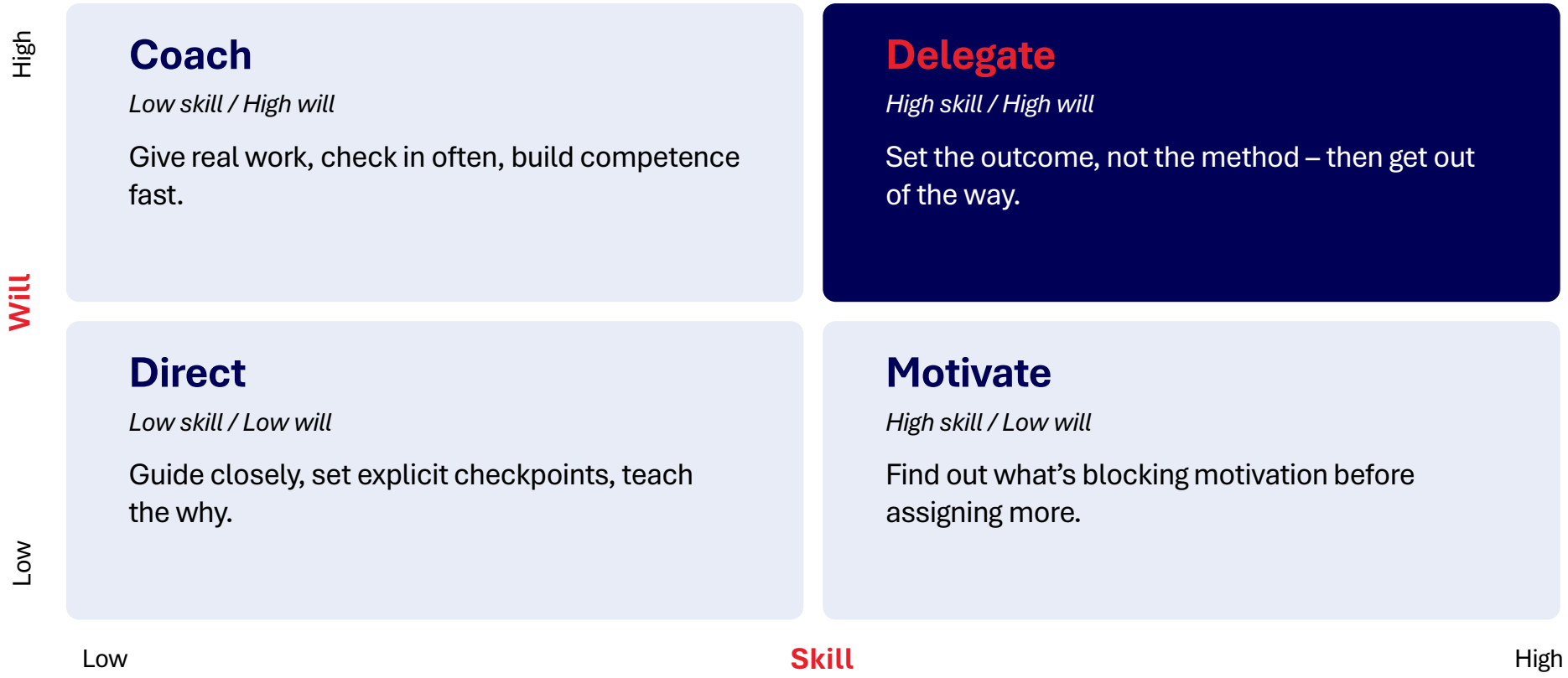
A direct question: "How confident are you? How much do you want this?"

Skill and will are per task, not a permanent label – and will drifts over time, so keep re-checking in your regular 1:1s.

Source: Adapted from Blanchard, K., Zigarmi, P., & Zigarmi, D. (2013). Leadership and the one minute manager: Increasing effectiveness through situational leadership II (Updated ed.). William Morrow; Landsberg, M. (1996). The Tao of coaching. HarperCollins Business.

The readiness matrix

Match Your Style to Their Skill and Will, Not to Your Comfort.



Source: Hersey & Blanchard (1969); Landsberg, M. (1996). The Tao of Coaching. HarperCollins Business.

Group activity 2

Now, Match a Delegation Style to a Real Person.

How it works

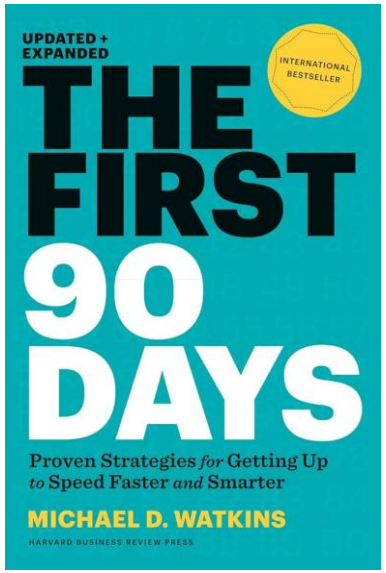
1. Pair up with someone from a different team
2. Describe one real team member's skill and will – without naming them
3. Your partner recommends direct, coach, motivate, or delegate – using the matrix from the last slide – and why
4. Swap roles and repeat
5. Note one delegation shift you'll make this week

Debrief question

What's one delegation shift you'll make this week?

Reference framework · Watkins (2013)

A structured 90-day plan moves your break-even point weeks earlier.



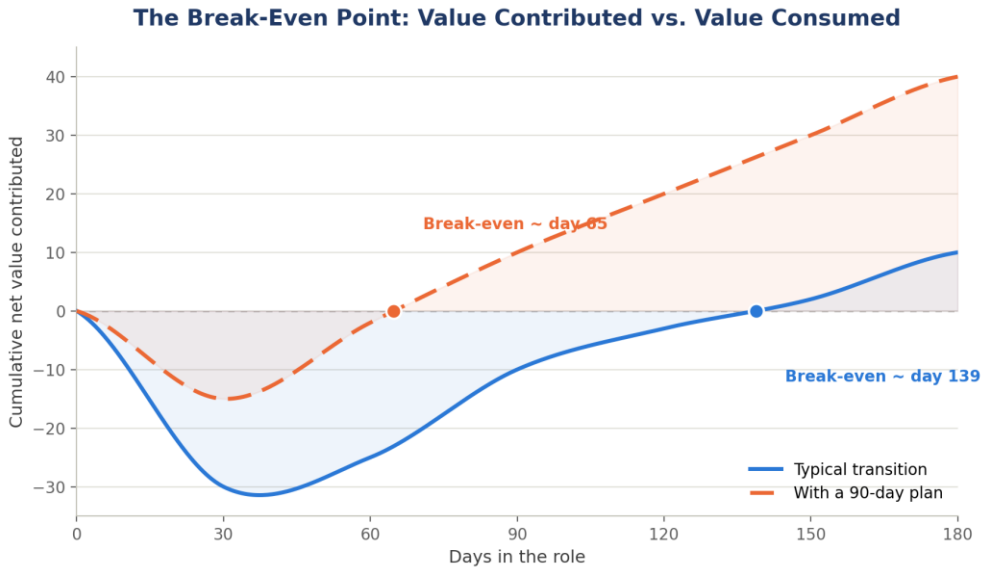
Watkins, M. D. (2013)

Adapts this classic HBR framework for any leadership transition, including your first management role.

The break-even point

The moment you've contributed as much value to the organization as you've consumed from it.

Most failed transitions never reach it. A structured plan shifts the break-even point earlier:



Source: Adapted from Watkins, M. D. (2013). The First 90 Days. Harvard Business Review Press.

Source: Watkins, M. D. (2013). The first 90 days. Harvard Business Review Press.

Reference framework · Watkins (2013)

Diagnose the Situation You've Inherited Before You Choose a Style.

S

Start-up

Building a team or function that didn't exist before.

T

Turnaround

Fixing a team that is visibly struggling.

A

Accelerated Growth

Scaling a team that's already working – fast.

R

Realignment

A team that looks fine but is quietly drifting off track.

S

Sustaining Success

A strong team that mainly needs you not to break it.

Your diagnosis changes everything downstream: turnarounds need fast, visible decisions; sustaining-success situations need you to listen before you touch anything.

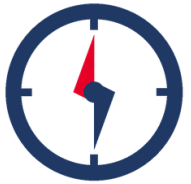
Source: Watkins, M. D. (2013). The first 90 days. Harvard Business Review Press.

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Field manual · Full roadmap

Twelve concrete actions carry you from day one to full accountability.



Days 1–30

Learn before you act

1. Declare the transition to yourself
2. Diagnose the situation you're inheriting
3. Run a structured 1:1 with every team member
4. Build a 30-day learning agenda
5. Watch for the expertise trap

Days 30–60

Negotiate, then act

6. Have five explicit conversations with your manager
7. Secure one early win that matters
8. Match delegation to readiness

Days 60–90

Build the team, lock in accountability

9. Reset expectations explicitly, in writing
10. Decide who stays, who grows, who moves
11. Build your support network
12. Draft your leadership transition plan

Source: Watkins, M. D. (2013). The first 90 days. Harvard Business Review Press.

Field manual · Days 1–30 · Learn before you act · Step 1 of 12

Declare the Transition to Yourself

1

Old success was personal output; new success is team output – capability, accountability, results delivered by others.

Write down, in one sentence, what “success” meant in your old role and what it means now. Read it before every 1:1 this month.

Source: Watkins, M. D. (2013). The first 90 days. Harvard Business Review Press.

Field manual · Days 1–30 · Learn before you act · Step 2 of 12

Diagnose the Situation You're Inheriting

2

Start-up, turnaround, accelerated growth, realignment, or sustaining success (STARS) – name it before you act.

Your diagnosis changes everything downstream: it determines how directive or how patient you need to be.

Source: Watkins, M. D. (2013). The first 90 days. Harvard Business Review Press.

Field manual · Days 1–30 · Learn before you act · Step 3 of 12

Run a Structured 1:1 With Every Team Member

3

Build an early read on each person's skill and will – it drives how you delegate next month.

Ask: what does this role actually involve day to day? What would you change if it were up to you?

Source: Watkins, M. D. (2013). The first 90 days. Harvard Business Review Press.

Field manual · Days 1–30 · Learn before you act · Step 4 of 12

Build a 30-Day Learning Agenda, Not an Action Plan

4

Understand the work, the informal network, and the history before you start changing things.

A manager who acts confidently on a wrong diagnosis does more damage than one who takes three extra weeks to get it right.

Source: Watkins, M. D. (2013). The first 90 days. Harvard Business Review Press.

Field manual · Days 1–30 · Learn before you act · Step 5 of 12

Watch Yourself for the Expertise Trap

5

Every time you're tempted to just do it yourself, ask: what does my team fail to learn today?

Name it out loud in your notes – this becomes evidence for the delegation section of your transition plan.

Source: Watkins, M. D. (2013). The first 90 days. Harvard Business Review Press.

Field manual · Days 30–60 · Negotiate, then act · Step 6 of 12

Have Five Explicit Conversations With Your Manager

6

Situation, expectations, style, resources, and your own development – don’t assume alignment, negotiate it.

Unclear expectations at this level are the fastest way to lose credibility with your own team later.

Source: Watkins, M. D. (2013). The first 90 days. Harvard Business Review Press.

Field manual · Days 30–60 · Negotiate, then act · Step 7 of 12

Secure One Early Win That Matters

7

Pick a real, visible priority; deliver it with the team, not around them – and give them the credit.

A good early win proves two things at once: that you can lead, and that the team is capable under your leadership.

Source: Watkins, M. D. (2013). The first 90 days. Harvard Business Review Press.

Field manual · Days 30–60 · Negotiate, then act · Step 8 of 12

Match Delegation to Each Person's Readiness

8

Direct, coach, motivate, or delegate – based on the skill/will read you built in Step 3.

This is the same readiness matrix from earlier in the session: getting the match wrong in either direction is the fastest way to create resentment or failure.

Source: Watkins, M. D. (2013). The first 90 days. Harvard Business Review Press.

Field manual · Days 60–90 · Build the team, lock in accountability · Step 9 of 12

Reset Expectations Explicitly, in Writing

9

Confirm what “done” looks like, how you’ll check in, and what to escalate versus decide.

Vague expectations are the root cause of most “accountability” problems.

Source: Watkins, M. D. (2013). The first 90 days. Harvard Business Review Press.

Field manual · Days 60–90 · Build the team, lock in accountability · Step 10 of 12

Decide Who Stays, Who Grows, Who Moves

10

You inherited this team – honestly assess whether you have the right capability in the right seats.

You don’t need to act on every gap immediately, but naming them now is part of the job.

Source: Watkins, M. D. (2013). The first 90 days. Harvard Business Review Press.

Field manual · Days 60–90 · Build the team, lock in accountability · Step 11 of 12

Build Your Support Network

11

Three to five people who'll give you honest, outside perspective on how you're really doing.

New managers who go quiet under pressure take longer to correct course and burn out faster.

Source: Watkins, M. D. (2013). The first 90 days. Harvard Business Review Press.

Field manual · Days 60–90 · Build the team, lock in accountability · Step 12 of 12

Draft Your Leadership Transition Plan

12

Pull Steps 1–11 together into the practical plan this program asks you to produce.

This is exactly what you'll start building in the final activity of today's session.

Source: Watkins, M. D. (2013). The first 90 days. Harvard Business Review Press.

Your turn

Now It's Your Turn to Draft the Plan.

- [ ] What situation am I actually in – and what does that demand of my style?
- [ ] What is each team member's current readiness, and what does that mean for how I delegate to them?
- [ ] Where have I been over-relying on my own expertise, and what will I hand off in the next 30 days?
- [ ] What expectations need to be made explicit – with my team, and with my own manager?
- [ ] What early win will I pursue, and how will I make sure the team gets the credit?

Wrap-up

Remember These Four Things Before You Go.



- Success now means results through others – not personal output.
- Match your delegation style to each person's skill and will, not your comfort.
- Watch for the three traps: over-relying on expertise, avoiding delegation, and leaving expectations unclear.
- Use the First 90 Days structure – learn, then negotiate and act, then build and lock in accountability – to pace your own transition.

Academic sources cited in this deck

These Are the Sources Behind Today's Session.

- Blanchard, K., Zigarmi, P., & Zigarmi, D. (2013). *Leadership and the one minute manager: Increasing effectiveness through* situational leadership II (Updated ed.). William Morrow.
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